



FRANMUN 2026

Franciscan sisters' school

DISEC committee: Research Report

**Regulating the Militarization and International Security of the Arctic Amid
Melting Ice and Emerging Shipping Routes.**



Disarmament

Definitions:

North Pole: The northernmost point on Earth, located in the Arctic Ocean. Unlike the South Pole, it is not located on land but on constantly moving sea ice.

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Trading Routes: Sea routes used to transport goods and resources between different parts of the world. As Arctic sea ice decreases, previously difficult northern routes are becoming more accessible for international shipping.

Global Warming: The long-term increase in the Earth's average temperature. The Arctic is particularly affected, with rising temperatures contributing to the rapid loss of sea ice and changes to Arctic ecosystems.

Environmental Protection: Efforts to preserve Arctic ecosystems and reduce the environmental damage caused by activities such as shipping, pollution, resource extraction, and climate change.

Maritime Spaces: Different areas of the sea that are governed by specific legal rights and responsibilities under international law, including territorial seas, exclusive economic zones, and international waters.

Northern Sea Route: A major Arctic shipping route that follows Russia's northern coastline, connecting the Atlantic and Pacific Oceans through Arctic waters. Its importance has increased as changing ice conditions make navigation possible for longer periods of the year.

Coast Guard: A maritime service responsible for protecting and monitoring coastal and sea areas. In the Arctic, coast guards play an important role in search and rescue, maritime safety, law enforcement, and responding to environmental emergencies such as oil spills.

Background:

The arctic, northernmost region of Earth, centered on the North Pole and characterized by distinctively polar conditions of climate, plant and animal life, and other physical features.

Until now, there are no definite and accurate borders for the arctic, it includes parts of Greenland, Svalbard, Siberia, Alaska, Canada, Labrador, Iceland and Europe. which made this area extremely fundamental and a point of contention geographically. Economically, the arctic is rich in oil, gas and strategic metals, according to the USGS, the arctic has 13% of the undiscovered oil and 30% of undiscovered natural gas, which categorizes the arctic as subject of dispute between powerful countries due to the natural resources that could benefit these countries financially.

As a result of the increasing amount of ice melting over the years, due to global warming, there are many trading routes opened. Unfortunately, these circumstances make the arctic security case even more complex since every country wants their best interests in these new shipping routes. In order to prevent the arctic from becoming a major security and military conflict zone, there have been many attempts to regulate and organize militarization and protect the emerging shipping routes from becoming a constant war zone.

For example: The Arctic Council (1996) which was created by the eight Arctic states to promote cooperation on environmental protection, sustainable development, science, and other Arctic issues. but its mandate deliberately excluded military security, leaving the growing militarization of the Arctic largely outside its regulatory framework, which caused the failure of this council.

Existing proposals primarily seek to deter conflict rather than prevent militarization. As melting ice opens new shipping routes and increases the Arctic's strategic value, a stronger international framework is needed to regulate military activities while preserving freedom of navigation and legitimate national security interests.

Treaties and organizations:

United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS): the convention lays down a comprehensive regime of law and order for the world's oceans, establishing rules for the

allocation of States' rights and jurisdiction in maritime spaces, the peaceful use of the oceans and the management of their resources.

Svalbard Treaty (1920): An international treaty recognizing Norwegian sovereignty over Svalbard, while giving citizens of other treaty states certain equal rights to access and conduct economic activities there.

Ilulissat Declaration (2008): A declaration by the five Arctic Ocean coastal states—Canada, Denmark, Norway, Russia, and the United States—affirming that existing international law, particularly UNCLOS, is the basis for resolving Arctic territorial and maritime disputes peacefully.

Agreement on Cooperation on Aeronautical and Maritime Search and Rescue in the Arctic (2011): A legally binding agreement among the eight Arctic states to coordinate search-and-rescue operations when people or ships are in distress in the Arctic.

Agreement on Cooperation on Marine Oil Pollution Preparedness and Response in the Arctic (2013): An agreement among the eight Arctic states to cooperate in preventing, preparing for, and responding to oil spills in the Arctic, which is increasingly important as shipping increases.

Arctic Council: The main intergovernmental forum for Arctic cooperation, established in 1996. It focuses mainly on environmental protection, sustainable development, and cooperation among the eight Arctic states and Indigenous peoples

International Maritime Organization (IMO): A UN specialized agency responsible for creating international rules for safe, secure, and environmentally responsible shipping. Its regulations are particularly relevant to emerging Arctic shipping routes.

NATO: A military and political alliance of 32 countries that has become increasingly relevant to Arctic security because several Arctic states are NATO members. It focuses on deterrence, collective defense, and military

cooperation, making it important to discussions about Arctic militarization.

TIMELINE:

1920 — Svalbard Treaty:

The Svalbard Treaty recognized Norway's sovereignty over the Svalbard islands while giving citizens of other signatory countries certain equal rights to access the islands and carry out economic activities. The treaty became an important part of the rules surrounding territory and access in the Arctic

1982 — United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS):

The United Nations Convention on the Law of Sea (UNCLOS) was adopted to set international laws for the use of the world's oceans and seas.

It established laws and rules for several areas such as territorial waters, exclusive economic zones (EEZ), and other nations' rights to use marine resources. These laws later became vital in the Arctic as countries began to discuss their maritime boundaries, resources, and shipping routes.

1996 — Establishment of the Arctic Council:

The arctic council was established by the 8 arctic states (Canada, the Kingdom of Denmark (via Greenland and the Faroe Islands), Finland, Iceland, Norway, the Russian Federation, Sweden, and the United States (via Alaska)) to provide cooperation on environmental protection, sustainable development and scientific research in the region. However, military security remains outside its mandate, leaving security and military issues to be addressed through other international means.

2008 — Ilulissat Declaration:

The 5 Arctic coastal states (Canada, Denmark, Norway, Russia, and the United States) signed the Ilulissat Declaration, assuring their commitment to resolving Arctic issues through existing international laws. The declaration demonstrated that these states wanted to manage territorial and maritime disputes through cooperation rather than conflict.

2011 — Arctic Search and Rescue Agreement:

The Arctic states signed the Arctic Search and Rescue Agreement to improve the cooperation between nations during emergencies in the region. It divided areas of responsibility between the countries involved and contributed to creating a better system for responding to accidents and people in danger as activity in the Arctic increased.

2010s — Increasing Accessibility of the Arctic:

During the 2010s, the rising temperatures and melting sea ice caused parts of the Arctic to be more accessible for shipping and resource growth. The increased access brought new economic opportunities; however, it also raised a lot of concerns about territorial claims, maritime security, and the growing military interest of Arctic states.

2022 — Russia's Invasion of Ukraine:

Russia's invasion of Ukraine increased the tension between Russia and other Western countries, including several Arctic states. Therefore, cooperation between Russia and other Arctic states became more difficult, raising concerns about how growing political tensions could affect security and military activity in the Arctic.

2022/Present — Growing Arctic Security Competition:

Ever since 2022, military and security concerns in the Arctic have significantly increased and received greater attention. Russia has continued developing its own military capabilities in the region, while other Arctic states have increased cooperation on defense and security. These developments have made it even more crucial to find ways and tools to reduce tensions and prevent the Arctic from becoming an area of greater military conflict zone and competition.

Present — The Need for Stronger International Cooperation:

Today, the Arctic is facing both environmental and security challenges. Melting ice is increasing access to shipping routes and natural resources, while military activity and tensions between states are creating new security concerns. With no single international framework focused on Arctic military activity alone, countries must cooperate to protect stability and prevent further militarization of the region.

The current situation:

The Arctic is experiencing some major environmental and geopolitical transformations. As global temperatures rise and the ice continues to melt, numerous areas are becoming more navigable and accessible for a longer period throughout the year.

This new crisis has significantly raised the Arctic importance regarding various aspects: international shipping, resource exploitation and strategic competition.

One of the most vital developments is the increased usage of the Northern Sea Route, the one running Russia's northern coastline and connecting both the Atlantic and Pacific oceans together.

And because of the enormous amount of melted sea ice, ships currently can use this route for longer periods, increasing the importance of international trade, alongside the strategic interests of Arctic states.

The ongoing accessibility of the arctic has significantly raised its strategic importance as well. The region contains a massive number of natural resources such as oil, gas and rare minerals. Simultaneously, its location is integral as well for several reasons such as defense, surveillance and shipping. Because of this, the Arctic states have a firm interest in protecting their sovereignty, monitoring activities in their waters, in addition to keeping valuable trade routes secure. This has established an inevitable challenge and an obstacle for the international community. And the main question remains: how can countries protect their national security interests while still maintaining cooperation and stability in the Arctic?

Meanwhile, the growing military activity in the arctic has raised a lot of security concerns. Russia considers the region vital to its own national security and economy, while maintaining a significant military presence there. Other Arctic states, including Canada, the United States and Nordic countries are all placing greater focus on Arctic security, surveillance and defense cooperation with several of them being NATO members.

As countries aim for strengthening their security and military capabilities in the region, tensions and competitions have increased, especially between Russia and the NATO members.

While shipping activity is increasing, new security challenges are emerging as well. More vessels entering Arctic waters cause higher risks of accidents, environmental emergencies, territorial disputes and military incidents. This leads to effective search and secure, safe navigation, emergency response and protection against marine pollution to be significantly crucial for our

committee. However, the Arctic's harsh weather conditions and limited infrastructure make it difficult for countries to respond quickly and effectively when crises occur.

Although existing international agreements provide important rules for cooperation, including maritime law, environmental protection and emergency actions, there is no single international framework specifically focused on regulating military activities in the Arctic. For instance, the Arctic Council works mainly on environmental protections, sustainable developments and other civilian issues, leaving military and security matters outside its mandate. This therefore leads to a gap in the current international systems, as there are limited international rules specifically addressing the growing military activity and security concerns in the Arctic.

The main purpose of the international community is to prevent the Arctic from becoming an area of increasing military competition, while still respecting the sovereignty and security interests of all Arctic states. As Arctic ice continues to melt and the accessibility of the region increases, countries must find ways to maintain peace and stability while protecting their legitimate interests. DISEC must therefore consider how international cooperation, the Law of the Sea, confidence building measures and responsible military conduct can help reduce tensions and keep the Arctic a secure and stable region.

Countries involved:

Russia: Russia regards the Arctic as a strategically vital region for its national security and economic development, particularly due to the importance of the Northern Sea Route. It opposes what it considers increasing NATO militarization in the region and emphasizes respect for national sovereignty, territorial integrity, and existing international law.

Canada: Canada advocates for a secure and rules-based Arctic supported by stronger surveillance and defense capabilities. It places particular emphasis on protecting its Arctic sovereignty and ensuring the security of emerging shipping routes, while maintaining cooperation with NATO allies and other Arctic states.

Denmark: Denmark's Arctic policy is closely linked to Greenland and the protection of Arctic sovereignty. It supports stronger NATO cooperation and enhances regional defense capabilities, while stressing the importance of international law, territorial integrity, and stability in the Arctic.

United States: The United States increasingly views the Arctic as a region of strategic importance due to its implications for national security, shipping, natural resources, and geopolitical competition. It supports strengthening military and Coast Guard capabilities to improve security, surveillance, and the protection of Arctic waterways.

Norway: Norway considers Russia's expanding military presence in the Arctic a significant security concern. It strongly supports NATO deterrence, enhanced surveillance, and greater protection of critical Arctic and North Atlantic maritime routes.

Iceland: Iceland generally supports maintaining the Arctic as a stable and low-tension region, while recognizing that changing geopolitical and environmental conditions require stronger security measures. As a NATO member, it contributes through surveillance, air-defense cooperation, and support for Allied operations in the North Atlantic and Arctic region.

Sweden: Since joining NATO, Sweden has placed greater emphasis on strengthening deterrence, surveillance, and defense cooperation in the Arctic. Its approach is particularly influenced by concerns over Russia's military activities and the need for closer coordination among Nordic and NATO members.

Finland: Finland supports a stable and cooperative Arctic governed by international law, while recognizing the importance of strengthening NATO's deterrence and defense capabilities. At the same time, it emphasizes sustainable development, regional cooperation, and the meaningful participation of Arctic states and Indigenous peoples.

Questions to consider:

What is your country's official position on the increasing militarization of the Arctic?

Does your country support the creation of an international framework regulating military activities in the Arctic? If so, what activities should be regulated?

How does your country balance its national security interests with the objective of preventing an Arctic arms race?

What is your country's position on freedom of navigation through emerging Arctic shipping routes?

Does your country consider existing international law, particularly UNCLOS, sufficient to regulate Arctic maritime disputes, or does it support additional agreements?

What confidence-building or de-escalation measures would your country support to reduce the risk of military incidents in the Arctic?

What role should the Arctic Council play in addressing security issues, given that its current mandate explicitly excludes military security?

How does your country view the relationship between increased commercial shipping and military security in the Arctic?

What responsibilities should Arctic states have for maintaining safe navigation, search and rescue, and emergency response as maritime traffic increases?

Resources:

<https://www.imo.org/en/ourwork/legal/pages/unitednationsconventiononthelawofthesea.aspx>

<https://arctic-council.org/explore/work/cooperation>

[The Svalbard Treaty](#)

[Ilulissat Declaration, 2008 - Arctic Portal](#)

<https://www.reuters.com/business/aerospace-defense/natos-arctic-moves-pose-direct-threat-russia-foreign-minister-lavrov-says-2026-08-31>

https://um.fi/current-affairs/-/asset_publisher/gc654PySnjTX/content/joint-statement-on-arctic-security-from-the-arctic-allies

<https://english.stm.dk/press/press-releases/joint-statement-on-greenland>

<https://www.whitehouse.gov/presidential-actions/2025/10/construction-of-arctic-security-cutters/?query-11-page=2>

https://www.regjeringen.no/en/documents/arctic_policy/id2830120/

<https://www.nato.int/en/news-and-events/articles/news/2025/05/28/nato-secretary-general-welcomes-icelandic-prime-minister-to-nato-headquarters>

<https://www.government.se/press-releases/2026/02/sweden-contributes-to-nato-operation-arctic-sentry/>

https://um.fi/cs/publications/-/asset_publisher/TVOLgBmLyZvu/content/finland-s-arctic-foreign-and-security-policy-policy-document-minister-for-foreign-affairs-november-2025/128338417

[United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea](#)

https://www.regjeringen.no/en/topics/foreign-affairs/international-law/innsikt/svalbard-treaty/id2354052/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

[UNCLOS — United Nations](#)

[Arctic Council](#)

https://arctic-council.org/news/ilulissat-declaration/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

https://arctic-council.org/about/agreements/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

[NASA — Arctic Sea Ice](#)

[IMO — Polar Code](#)

https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_192144.htm?utm_source=chatgpt.com

[Arctic Council — News](#)